Baselines for an agile product: what executives can expect, and how funding follows

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An agile team learns as it goes. An executive has to say how much, by when, and what will be delivered. Both are right. This article shows how to hold them together with a short set of baselines, and then hands over to the Phase 1 plan to read.

5 baselines | 4 funding steps | 1 funnel | 2026-10-27

The problem in one minute

Funding wants a number and a date. Agile says the plan will change as we learn. Put those side by side and each side hears the other as a risk:

What executives hear

- “We cannot say what it will cost.”
- “The scope will move.”
- “Trust us.”

What the team hears

- “Fix the plan now, before you know enough.”
- “Any change is a failure.”
- “Report progress, not learning.”

The way through is not to pick a side. It is to decide **what must stay fixed**, so executives can rely on it, and **what may move**, so the team can learn. A baseline is that decision, written down and agreed.

A baseline is not a contract. It is an agreed starting line. When something moves, it moves in the open, against the baseline, with the right person deciding.

Five baselines

Five short baselines cover what executives need. Each one has a part that stays fixed and a part that can move.

Baseline	Fixed Executives can rely on	Moves The team can learn	Who decides a change
1. Outcome	The few results the product must deliver, and how each is measured	How we reach them	Sponsor

Baseline	Fixed Executives can rely on	Moves The team can learn	Who decides a change
2. Scope boundary	What is in the first release, what is out, and what is ruled out	The detail inside each item; the order inside a phase	Product owner, with the sponsor for anything that crosses the line
3. Roadmap and gates	The phases, the critical path and the gates, each accepted on evidence	Work packages inside a phase, within the gate dates	Product owner; sponsor if a gate moves
4. Funding envelope	A ceiling for the release, a range that narrows at each gate, and a held reserve	Where money goes inside the ceiling	Sponsor and finance
5. Ownership after go-live	A named product owner and a funded line for improvement	The improvement backlog	Sponsor

Baselines 1 to 4 let executives approve the first release. Baseline 5 is the one that is usually missing, and the next section explains why it matters most.

What to expect: a range that narrows

Early on, nobody can give an honest single figure. The honest answer is a range, and a promise about when the range will narrow. Each gate is a moment when something real has been built or tested, so the range gets tighter.

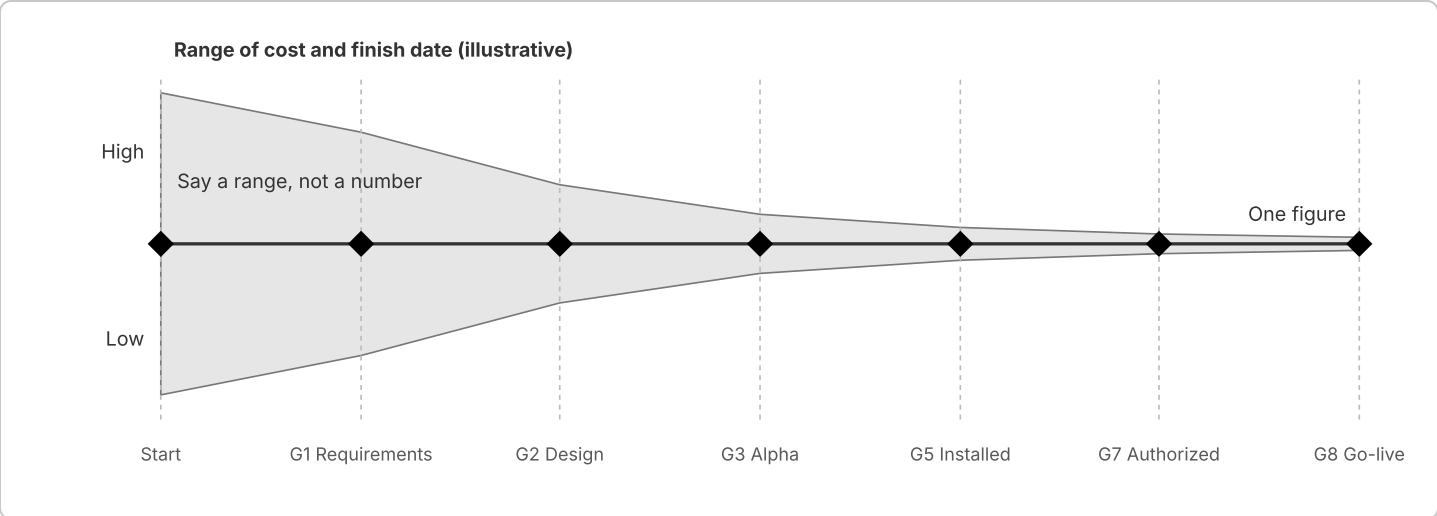


Figure 1: The range of cost and finish date narrows at each gate. Illustrative shape only, not a forecast.

Stage	What executives see	What is firm	The decision they make
Discover	Requirements baseline, a taxonomy, a content audit	Outcomes and scope boundary	Approve the design stage

Stage	What executives see	What is firm	The decision they make
Design	Architecture sign-off, mock-ups agreed with the business	The shape of the solution	Approve the build
Alpha	A working system that staff can use and learn on	What the product actually does	Confirm the range, release the next tranche
Isolated build	Installed and tested on the isolated network	Cost to finish	Approve the security assessment
Go-live	Authority to operate, then launch and support	The final figure	Go or no-go; fund what comes next

The largest drop in uncertainty comes at the alpha. That is why it is worth doing early, with a real build and real users, before the harder and costlier steps on the isolated network.

Where agile fits, and where it does not

This plan is not all iterative, and it should not be. Some parts need a fixed order because a later step cannot start until an earlier one is accepted.

Learning space: iterate here

- The alpha on a connected network
- Content and taxonomy decisions
- Publishing screens and the author experience
- Order of work inside a phase

Fixed order: plan here

- Pipeline dry run before installation on the isolated network
- Defects closed before the security control assessment
- Authorization before launch
- Publishing authority agreed before owners are assigned

That mix is what makes the baselines honest. The team has room to learn where learning pays. Executives get firm gates where a mistake would be expensive.

Bridge to funding: fund the product, not just the project

A project has an end date. A product does not. If the money stops at go-live, the product starts to decay on day one: pages go stale, owners drift, and the next release has no home. Staff then lose trust in the site, which is the problem the project set out to fix.

Product management is the habit that closes this gap. It asks for four things, cheapest first.

1. Free

No approval, no post, no budget. Name an outcome owner. Publish the gate results. Report on outcomes, such as pages current and owned, not on activity.

2. Inside funded posts

Give an existing role the product owner duties. Add a standing review of the improvement backlog each quarter.

3. One decision

Set aside an improvement line that continues after closeout, sized as a small share of the build cost. It needs a decision, not a reorganization.

4. Organizational

Move from project funding to standing product funding. This is bigger than one project can settle, so name it and hand it to the right forum.

Time-sensitive. Step 3 has to be decided before closeout, while the delivery team and the money are still there. After closeout it is a new ask against a cold start.

Five concerns to watch

- **Funding stops at closeout.** The gating issue, covered above.
- **No single owner of outcomes.** Many people publish, but nobody answers for the result.
- **Activity is reported, not outcomes.** “We published 200 pages” says little. “90 percent are owned and current” says more.
- **Skills decay.** The people who learned the platform move on, and the knowledge goes with them.
- **The next release has no home.** Later waves need an owner and a line, or they never start.

When something moves

Change will come. The baselines make it cheap to handle, because everyone knows what changed against what.

What moves	Handled as	Decided by
Detail inside a work package, or order inside a phase	Normal product backlog work	Product owner
A gate date or a package that gates another	A recorded change with its effect on the critical path	Product owner, sponsor told
Scope crosses the boundary, in or out	A change request: what it adds, what it displaces, what it costs	Sponsor
Cost passes the envelope or eats the reserve	A funding decision, with the options set out	Sponsor and finance

Every change request answers the same four questions: what is proposed, why, what is the effect on cost and schedule, and what happens if we do nothing. Short and plain.

Questions an executive can ask at any gate

- Which baseline does this change, and who decided it?
- What evidence was accepted at this gate? A working system, a test result, a signed authorization?
- Has the range narrowed since the last gate? If not, why not?
- What are we not doing, and has that changed?
- Who owns the outcome after go-live, and what funds it?

Next: read the Phase 1 plan

The baselines above need something concrete to attach to. The Phase 1 article has that: a roadmap diagram with nine gates, a storyboard of who gains and when, the concepts being tested, and a work breakdown structure with the critical path.

Phase 1 roadmap, concepts and work breakdown for an on-premises intranet

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Drafted with Claude.ai from a private project hub, then generalized. No product, team or system names. The funnel is illustrative and is not a forecast.